

India's Oil & Gas Legislative and Regulatory Framework

A reference document on upstream exploration & production law, environmental restrictions, offshore governance, and recent (2025-2026) legislative reform in India — compiled for use as a RAG knowledge source.

Compiled: July 2026 | Coverage: Central acts, rules, licensing policy, environmental clearance regime, eco-sensitive zone restrictions, offshore law, and illustrative case studies of site-specific restrictions/approvals.

This document synthesizes publicly available legal commentary, government notifications, and news reporting current as of mid-2026. It is intended as background/context material for research and retrieval-augmented systems, not as a substitute for the primary statutes, official gazette notifications, or legal advice. Always verify against the Ministry of Petroleum & Natural Gas (mopng.gov.in), the Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change (moefcc.gov.in), and India Code (indiacode.nic.in) before relying on any provision operationally.

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1. Constitutional & Institutional Framework

India has a federal constitutional structure in which legislative power over petroleum is divided between the Union and the States. Under **Article 246** of the Constitution, read with the Union and Concurrent Lists of the Seventh Schedule, the regulation and development of oilfields, mineral oil resources, and petroleum products fall predominantly within the legislative competence of **Parliament**. State legislatures retain power over ancillary matters such as land access, right of way, water use, and local administration relevant to onshore operations.

By virtue of **Article 297** of the Constitution, all resources of the territorial waters, the continental shelf, and the exclusive economic zone (EEZ) of India — including petroleum in its natural state found there — vest in the Union of India, not in any State. This is the constitutional basis for the Union government's exclusive control over offshore exploration and production.

Key institutions

- **Ministry of Petroleum & Natural Gas (MoPNG)** — the nodal ministry for exploration, production, refining, distribution, marketing, import/export and conservation of petroleum and petroleum products, as allocated under the Government of India (Allocation of Business) Rules, 1961.
- **Directorate General of Hydrocarbons (DGH)** — MoPNG's technical arm (established 1993), responsible for monitoring exploration & production (E&P) activity, managing Production Sharing/Revenue Sharing Contracts, and administering licensing rounds (OALP, DSF, HELP).
- **Petroleum and Natural Gas Regulatory Board (PNGRB)** — statutory regulator (under the PNGRB Act, 2006) for downstream activities: refining, pipelines, gas transmission/distribution, and market development; also authorises city gas distribution networks and the national gas pipeline grid.
- **Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change (MoEFCC)** — administers environmental clearance, forest clearance, wildlife clearance, Coastal Regulation Zone rules and Eco-Sensitive Zone notifications that constrain where and how E&P projects may proceed.
- **Oil Industry Safety Directorate (OISD)** and the **Directorate General of Mines Safety** — safety regulators for oilfield operations under the Mines Act and sector-specific safety rules.
- **National Board for Wildlife (NBWL)**, through its Standing Committee — approves (or declines) project proposals, including E&P drilling, that fall within or near protected areas and their eco-sensitive zones.

2. Core Legislation Governing Upstream Oil & Gas

2.1 Oilfields (Regulation and Development) Act, 1948 ("ORD Act")

The principal Central statute governing the regulation of oilfields and the development of mineral oil resources in India. Historically it conferred rule-making power on the Union government over the grant of mining leases (now "petroleum leases"), royalty rates, and terms of exploration and production. It was substantially modernised by the **Oilfields (Regulation and Development) Amendment Act, 2025** (see Section 3).

2.2 Petroleum and Natural Gas Rules

Delegated legislation framed under the ORD Act that lays down the detailed procedure for grant of exploration licences and mining/petroleum leases, both onshore and offshore. The historical Petroleum and Natural Gas Rules, 1959 (in force for over six decades) were replaced by the **Petroleum and Natural Gas Rules, 2025**.

2.3 Territorial Waters, Continental Shelf, Exclusive Economic Zone and Other Maritime Zones Act, 1976

Establishes India's maritime zones and empowers the Union government to grant licences for exploring and exploiting the resources of the continental shelf and EEZ — the constitutional and statutory basis for offshore E&P activity beyond the territorial sea.

2.4 Offshore Areas Mineral (Development and Regulation) Act, 2002 (OAMDR Act)

Came into force in 2010; governs exploration and production of minerals — including, in practice, hydrocarbon-adjacent seabed minerals — in India's offshore areas, distinct from the ORD Act framework used for oil and gas leases. It was substantially amended in 2023 to introduce competitive auction as the method of allocating operating rights.

2.5 Petroleum and Natural Gas Regulatory Board Act, 2006

Establishes PNGRB and regulates refining, processing, storage, transportation, distribution, marketing and sale of petroleum, petroleum products and natural gas — i.e., the midstream/downstream segment, as distinct from upstream E&P covered by the ORD Act.

2.6 Environmental statutes applicable to the sector

- Environment (Protection) Act, 1986 — the umbrella statute under which environmental clearance notifications, CRZ rules, and Eco-Sensitive Zone notifications are issued.
- Water (Prevention and Control of Pollution) Act, 1974.
- Air (Prevention and Control of Pollution) Act, 1981.
- Forest (Conservation) Act, 1980 and the Wild Life (Protection) Act, 1972 — trigger forest clearance and NBWL wildlife clearance respectively where a project falls on forest land or in/near a protected area.

3. The 2025 Reform Wave: ORDA 2025, PNG Rules 2025 & the New Royalty Framework

Between March 2025 and May 2026, India undertook the most significant overhaul of its upstream legal framework in decades, executed in three linked steps.

3.1 Oilfields (Regulation and Development) Amendment Act, 2025

Passed by both Houses of Parliament and assented to by the President on **28 March 2025**; it came into force on **15 April 2025**. Principal changes include:

- **Terminology shift:** "mining lease" is replaced by "**petroleum lease**" as the operative instrument for exploration, development and production — a single consolidated lease replacing the earlier layered licence/lease structure.

- **Expanded definition of "mineral oils"** to explicitly include crude oil, condensate, coal bed methane, shale oil/gas, tight oil/gas, and gas hydrates — bringing unconventional hydrocarbons squarely within the regulatory net. Coal, lignite and helium are expressly excluded (they remain under the Mines and Minerals (Development and Regulation) Act, 1957).
- **New Section 4A:** no person may undertake prospecting, exploration, development or production of mineral oils anywhere in India (including territorial waters, continental shelf and EEZ) except under a valid petroleum lease — with legacy leases/licences granted before commencement continuing to be valid under a savings clause (Section 13A).
- **Stability/no-adverse-alteration clause (Section 5(3)):** the terms of a petroleum lease must "remain stable" for the duration of the lease and cannot be altered to the lessee's disadvantage — a significant investor-protection assurance aimed at foreign and domestic capital.
- **Decriminalisation of offences:** violations that previously carried imprisonment (up to six months) now attract monetary penalties only — up to **₹25 lakh**, plus **₹10 lakh per day** for continuing non-compliance, adjudicated by a Central Government-appointed officer (Joint Secretary rank or above), with appeal to the Appellate Tribunal under the PNGRB Act.
- **Centralisation:** the Central Government becomes the exclusive authority to grant petroleum leases, reducing State-level jurisdictional overlap for licensing (though States retain land, water and local administration powers).
- **Environmental and decarbonisation provisions:** rule-making power extended to safety, environmental protection during operations and at abandonment/decommissioning, unitisation of leases across States/UTs/offshore areas with reservoir continuity, and measures to reduce carbon/greenhouse gas emissions, including repurposing oilfields for hydrogen production or carbon capture, utilisation and storage (CCUS).

Note: Critics — including some labour and civil-society groups — have argued the Act reduces State fiscal autonomy over royalties/cess, loosens procedural checks compared to the old auction-based mining-lease regime, and weakens the historical primacy of public-sector operators (ONGC, Oil India Ltd) relative to private and foreign lessees. This is a live policy debate and is presented here for balance, not as a resolved conclusion.

3.2 Petroleum and Natural Gas Rules, 2025

Issued under the Amendment Act to replace the Petroleum and Natural Gas Rules, 1959 with a consolidated, 65-rule framework. Key features:

- A **single petroleum lease** now covers exploration, development and production of all hydrocarbon types (including unconventional resources) in one instrument.
- Leases may run for **up to 30 years** and can be extended for the full economic life of a field.
- Petroleum lease **applications must be decided within 180 days**, addressing long-standing delays.
- Lessees may undertake **decarbonisation and integrated energy projects** at oilfield sites, and may jointly develop or share infrastructure facilities by mutual agreement, subject to an Annual Declaration of installed/utilised/excess infrastructure capacity to the Government.
- **Arbitration seat:** New Delhi where all parties are Indian-incorporated companies; a neutral seat may be chosen where a foreign company is a party.
- A **stabilisation mechanism** allows lessees to claim compensation for adverse changes in law (e.g., new taxes, royalty increases, or levies) that materially affect commercial viability — this interacts directly with the royalty framework described below.

3.3 Revised Royalty Framework (notified 8 May 2026)

The third pillar of the reform cycle. It rationalises decades of accreted, inconsistent royalty rate structures (spanning the nomination regime, pre-NELP contracts, NELP, HELP, the Discovered Small Field policy and CBM policy) into a single framework featuring:

- A standardised **wellhead price deduction formula** to simplify royalty computation.
- A **basin-based classification** that ties royalty incentives to geological risk (i.e., higher-risk/frontier basins attract more favourable royalty terms to encourage exploration).
- Application across **both legacy and future production regimes** — nomination areas, pre-NELP contracts, NELP blocks, CBM areas, DSF contracts and HELP blocks alike.
- Because this is a downward revision of rates, it does not itself trigger the PNGR 2025 stabilisation clause — but a future upward revision of royalty could, depending on lease terms, engage that protection for existing lessees.

4. Licensing Regimes: Nomination, NELP, HELP/OALP, DSF

India's E&P licensing policy has evolved through several generations, and different vintages of blocks may still operate under their original contractual terms even after the 2025 reforms (subject to the savings clause in ORDA 2025).

Regime	Period	Key Features
Nomination Regime	Until 1980	Exploration rights given only to state-owned entities (ONGC, Oil India).
Pre-NELP rounds	1990s	28 discovered fields (1991-93) and 28 exploration blocks (1990-97) auctioned to private/
NELP (New Exploration Licensing Policy)	1997-2010 block awards	International competitive bidding; selected entities enter Production Sharing Contracts (PSCs)
HELP (Hydrocarbon Exploration & Licensing Policy) / OALP (Open Acreage Licensing Policy)	From 2016	Unified licensing for all hydrocarbon types under one licence; Revenue Sharing Contract (RSC)
Discovered Small Field (DSF) Policy	From 2016	Enables commercial development of marginal/previously uneconomical discovered fields
Coal Bed Methane (CBM) Policy	From late 1990s	Separate licensing track for CBM extraction, including permission to Coal India Ltd and i

The **10th OALP bidding round** was launched on 11 February 2025, described by the Government as the largest E&P bidding round globally, and was explicitly timed to follow the ORD Amendment Act. A further round in 2026 offered up to **50 additional oil and gas blocks** for exploration, as part of India's push to reduce import dependence (currently roughly 83-85% of crude oil and around 47-50% of natural gas requirements are met through imports). The Petroleum Minister has stated that the reforms are also opening up acreage previously classified as "no-go zones" for exploration bidding.

5. Offshore Areas: Law, Rights, and the Power to Close Areas

Two distinct offshore legal regimes operate side by side. Oil and gas leases in offshore blocks are granted by the Union government under the **ORD Act / PNG Rules** framework (Section 2 above). Separately, the **Offshore Areas Mineral (Development and Regulation) Act, 2002** (in force from 15 January 2010) governs other offshore mineral resources and related operating rights (reconnaissance permits, exploration licences, production leases) in the territorial waters, continental shelf and EEZ.

5.1 Statutory power to close offshore areas

Section 9 of the OAMDR Act, 2002 gives the Central Government an express, written power to **close any offshore area — in part or in whole — for a specified period**, for reasons including:

- Preservation of the natural environment and prevention of pollution;
- Avoiding danger to public health;
- Protecting communication or ensuring the safety of any offshore structure or platform; or
- Conservation of offshore minerals.

This is the direct statutory mechanism by which the Government can restrict or suspend operating rights in a defined offshore area — closely matching the kind of "Government has recently closed/restricted this area" scenario relevant to RAG queries about current restrictions.

5.2 Other offshore requirements

- Operating rights may only be granted to Indian nationals or companies as defined under the Companies Act; production leases for atomic minerals or other "prescribed substances" require consultation with the Department of Atomic Energy.
- Holders must comply with directions of the competent authority or the **Indian Coast Guard** regarding national security, safety and integrity.
- Where a Government company partners in a joint venture for exploration/production, the joint-venture partner must be selected through a competitive process, and the Government company must hold more than 74% of paid-up share capital in that joint venture.
- The **Offshore Areas Mineral (Development and Regulation) Amendment Act, 2023** introduced **auction** as the method for allocating offshore operating rights (previously no commercial mining activity had in fact occurred offshore under this Act despite it being in force since 2010).
- The **Offshore Areas Operating Right Rules, 2024**, framed under the 2002 Act (as amended), operationalise competitive bidding, environmental impact assessment requirements and continuous monitoring obligations, and align India's offshore regime with its obligations under UNCLOS (the UN Convention on the Law of the Sea).

6. Environmental Regulation of Oil & Gas Operations

Environmental law is where most of the practical "can I drill here / is this area restricted" questions in the Indian oil & gas context actually get answered. Four overlapping regimes matter most.

6.1 Environmental Clearance (EIA) Process

Under the Environment (Protection) Act, 1986, projects including oil and gas exploration, drilling and production require **prior environmental clearance (EC)** based on an Environmental Impact Assessment (EIA), governed by the EIA Notification framework issued by MoEFCC. Historically, clearance for offshore and certain onshore E&P activity was centralised with MoEFCC; more recent policy direction has moved some categories of environmental clearance to **State-level authorities**, and in some categories has relaxed the requirement for a public hearing/EIA report — a change that has drawn criticism from environmental groups concerned about weaker scrutiny, and support from industry citing faster project timelines. Both perspectives are part of the ongoing public debate.

6.2 Coastal Regulation Zone (CRZ) Rules

First notified in February 1991 under the Environment (Protection) Act, 1986, and most recently consolidated in the **CRZ Notification, 2019** (which replaced the 2011 notification). CRZ rules regulate construction and industrial activity within defined distances of the coastline and tidal water bodies, and are directly relevant to onshore-adjacent and near-shore oil and gas infrastructure.

- **CRZ-I** — ecologically sensitive areas (mangroves, coral reefs, biosphere reserves) and the inter-tidal zone. No new construction generally permitted, though **exploration of natural gas and extraction of salt are among the narrow permitted exceptions**, along with Department of Atomic Energy projects and select strategic/foreshore facilities.
- **CRZ-II** — already-developed coastal areas within municipal limits; construction subject to town planning norms.
- **CRZ-III** — relatively undisturbed rural/urban coastal areas outside CRZ-I/II; limited to agriculture and specified public facilities.
- **CRZ-IV** — the aquatic area from the low tide line out to territorial limits (subdivided into IV-A, up to 12 nautical miles, and IV-B for tidal water bodies); traditional fishing is unrestricted, and this is the zone within which offshore platforms and pipelines typically require CRZ clearance in addition to environmental clearance.

All CRZ-regulated activity requires prior clearance integrated with the applicable State/UT Coastal Zone Management Plan (CZMP), administered jointly by the National Coastal Zone Management Authority (NCZMA) and State-level Coastal Zone Management Authorities.

6.3 Eco-Sensitive Zones (ESZ) Around Protected Areas

ESZs (also called Ecologically Fragile Areas) are buffer zones notified by MoEFCC around National Parks and Wildlife Sanctuaries under the Environment (Protection) Act, 1986, following guidelines first issued in 2011 and refined since. An ESZ can extend **up to 10 km** from a protected area's boundary — further where ecological corridors require it — and is meant to act as a "shock absorber," regulating (not necessarily banning) commercial, industrial and infrastructure activity nearby.

- A 2022 Supreme Court order initially mandated a minimum **1 km** ESZ around every protected area nationwide and banned permanent structures within it; this was **modified in April 2023** after concerns that a blanket ban would harm the hundreds of villages located inside these zones. The

revised position permits small permanent structures and normal Forest Department eco-development activity, and exempts areas already covered by MoEFCC's own site-specific draft ESZ notifications.

- ESZ notifications typically **prohibit commercial mining, polluting industries, and large new tourism infrastructure**, while regulating (rather than fully banning) traditional livelihoods.
- Whether oil and gas exploration/drilling is permitted within a given ESZ is decided case-by-case, generally requiring clearance from the **Forest Advisory Committee** and the **National Board for Wildlife's Standing Committee** (see Section 7 case studies below).

6.4 Forest & Wildlife Clearances

Where a proposed well pad, access road or pipeline falls on notified forest land, clearance is required under the **Forest (Conservation) Act, 1980** from the Forest Advisory Committee. Where the project falls within a protected area or its eco-sensitive zone, additional clearance under the **Wild Life (Protection) Act, 1972** is required from the **National Board for Wildlife**. Projects are frequently approved only for the exploratory drilling phase, with an explicit prohibition on commercial extraction within the ESZ even if hydrocarbons are discovered — commercial development, if any, must then take place from well sites located outside the ESZ boundary (directional/lateral drilling techniques are typically used to reach reservoirs from outside the restricted zone).

7. Case Studies: Restricted, Closed, or Conditionally Approved Areas

These illustrative, real examples show how the legal framework above operates in practice — useful for grounding RAG answers about specific area-level restrictions.

Kumbhalgarh Wildlife Sanctuary Eco-Sensitive Zone, Rajasthan (notified 15 January 2026)

MoEFCC formally declared an Eco-Sensitive Zone extending 0-1 km around Kumbhalgarh Wildlife Sanctuary in the Aravalli range (Udaipur, Pali and Rajsamand districts), covering roughly 243 sq. km and 94 villages. The notification prohibits commercial mining, polluting industries, brick kilns and new large tourism infrastructure, while regulating (not banning) traditional livelihoods, under the Environment (Protection) Act, 1986. This is a direct example of a Government notification newly restricting extractive activity in a defined area for biodiversity-protection reasons.

Hollongapar Gibbon Wildlife Sanctuary Eco-Sensitive Zone, Assam-Nagaland border (approved late 2024/early 2025)

The Standing Committee of the National Board for Wildlife approved **exploratory drilling only** for Vedanta Group's Cairn Oil & Gas within the ESZ of the Hollongapar Gibbon Wildlife Sanctuary (home to the endangered Hoolock gibbon), in Block AA-ONHP-2017/4, roughly 13 km from the sanctuary. A joint site inspection by MoEFCC, the Wildlife Institute of India and the Assam Forest Department found limited immediate impact from exploratory drilling but explicitly **recommended against any commercial drilling or extraction within the ESZ**, even if reserves are found. The operator gave a written undertaking that any commercial extraction, if reserves are discovered, would be carried out from well sites **outside** the ESZ boundary, and that no hazardous substances would be used during exploration. The sanctuary's ESZ spans about 264.92 sq. km, connecting to the Dissoi Valley Reserve Forest and forests across the Nagaland border. This case shows the typical conditional-approval pattern: exploration permitted, commercial extraction restricted to outside the sensitive zone.

Statutory power to close offshore areas — OAMDR Act, 2002, Section 9

As set out in Section 5.1 above, the Central Government holds a standing statutory power to close any offshore area, in part or whole, for a specified period, for reasons of environmental preservation, public health, safety of structures, or mineral conservation. Any RAG query along the lines of "has the government closed this offshore block" should be checked against orders issued under this section, communicated directly to the relevant permittee/licensee/lessee, and published in the Official Gazette where applicable.

General Eco-Sensitive Zone litigation backdrop — Supreme Court, 2022 (order) / 2023 (modification)

Following a 2022 Supreme Court direction mandating a minimum 1 km ESZ around every protected area in India and banning permanent structures within it, the Court modified its own order in April 2023 in response to concerns about the impact on villages inside these zones. Site-specific MoEFCC ESZ notifications (like Kumbhalgarh above) now generally govern in place of the blanket rule, and each notification's specific list of prohibited/regulated/permitted activities — not a single nationwide rule — determines whether a given oil and gas-related activity is restricted in a particular ESZ.

8. Safety Regulation of Oilfield Operations

- **Mines Act, 1952 and Oil Mines Regulations, 2017** — health, safety and welfare of workers at oilfields, enforced by the Directorate General of Mines Safety.

- **Petroleum and Natural Gas (Safety in Offshore Operations) Rules, 2008** — framed under the ORD Act specifically for offshore fields, prescribing safety standards for offshore installations.
- **Oil Industry Safety Directorate (OISD)** — issues technical safety standards followed across the industry (though many OISD standards are recommendatory rather than directly statutory, they are commonly mandated through licence/lease conditions and downstream regulator requirements).

9. Foreign Investment Rules for the Sector

Under India's Foreign Direct Investment (FDI) Policy, read with the Foreign Exchange Management Act, 1999 (FEMA), **100% FDI is permitted under the automatic route** (i.e., without prior Government approval) for exploration and production activities in oil and gas fields. A foreign company may operate either independently or in consortium with an Indian partner.

An important restriction applies under **Press Note 3 (2020)**, issued by the Department for Promotion of Industry and Internal Trade: entities from, or beneficially owned by persons in, any country that **shares a land border with India** require prior Government approval (the "Government Route") for any investment into India, including in the oil and gas sector.

India's produced crude oil and natural gas must, as a matter of policy, be **sold within the domestic market** — India does not permit export of domestically produced crude oil, reflecting its status as a large net energy importer (roughly 83-85% of crude requirements and around half of natural gas requirements are currently met by imports).

10. Site Restoration, Abandonment & Decommissioning

Production Sharing Contracts and Revenue Sharing Contracts require the contractor to remove equipment and installations from the contract area at the end of operations, in line with an agreed abandonment plan. The **Site Restoration and Abandonment Guidelines for Petroleum Operations (MoPNG, April 2018)** set out detailed obligations, including establishment of a **Site Restoration Fund (SRF)** by the E&P entity, to which annual contributions are made to cover eventual decommissioning and restoration costs for both offshore and onshore sites.

11. Recent Developments Timeline (2023-2026)

Date	Development
2023	Offshore Areas Mineral (Development and Regulation) Amendment Act, 2023 introduces auction-based allocation o
2024	Offshore Areas Operating Right Rules, 2024 notified, operationalising competitive bidding and EIA/monitoring requir
Dec 2024 / Jan 2025	NBWL Standing Committee approves exploratory-only oil/gas drilling within the Hollongapar Gibbon Wildlife Sanctu
11 Feb 2025	10th OALP bidding round launched — described as the largest E&P bidding round globally at the time.
12 Mar 2025	Lok Sabha passes the Oilfields (Regulation and Development) Amendment Bill, 2024.
28 Mar 2025	Oilfields (Regulation and Development) Amendment Act, 2025 receives Presidential assent.
15 Apr 2025	ORDA 2025 comes into force; introduces "petroleum lease" terminology, Section 4A licence requirement, stability cl
2025 (mid-year)	Draft Petroleum and Natural Gas Rules, 2025 released for public consultation; Petroleum and Natural Gas Rules, 20
15 Jan 2026	MoEFCC notifies Eco-Sensitive Zone around Kumbhalgarh Wildlife Sanctuary, Rajasthan (~243 sq km), restricting o
2026	New upstream licensing round offers up to 50 additional oil and gas blocks for exploration.
8 May 2026	Revised, basin-based royalty framework notified under the ORD Act/PNGR 2025, rationalising royalty rates across l
FY26 (Apr 2025-Feb 2026)	India's crude oil production rises to 25.63 MMT for the period; natural gas output grows 6.4% year-on-year; sector p

12. Glossary of Key Terms & Abbreviations

Term	Meaning
ORD Act	Oilfields (Regulation and Development) Act, 1948
ORDA 2025	Oilfields (Regulation and Development) Amendment Act, 2025
PNG Rules	Petroleum and Natural Gas Rules (2025, replacing the 1959 Rules)
MoPNG	Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas
DGH	Directorate General of Hydrocarbons
PNGRB	Petroleum and Natural Gas Regulatory Board
MoEFCC	Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change
NBWL	National Board for Wildlife
OAMDR Act	Offshore Areas Mineral (Development and Regulation) Act, 2002
EEZ	Exclusive Economic Zone
CRZ	Coastal Regulation Zone
ESZ	Eco-Sensitive Zone (also "Ecologically Fragile Area")
EIA / EC	Environmental Impact Assessment / Environmental Clearance
HELP	Hydrocarbon Exploration and Licensing Policy (2016)
OALP	Open Acreage Licensing Policy
NELP	New Exploration Licensing Policy (1997-2010 block awards)
DSF	Discovered Small Field Policy
CBM	Coal Bed Methane
PSC / RSC	Production Sharing Contract / Revenue Sharing Contract
PEL / PML	Petroleum Exploration Licence / Petroleum Mining Lease (pre-2025 terminology)
OISD	Oil Industry Safety Directorate
SRF	Site Restoration Fund
FDI	Foreign Direct Investment
FEMA	Foreign Exchange Management Act, 1999
UNCLOS	United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea

Primary sources to consult for verification

- India Code — indiacode.nic.in (full statute texts)
- Ministry of Petroleum & Natural Gas — mopng.gov.in

- Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change — moefcc.gov.in / environmentclearance.nic.in
- Directorate General of Hydrocarbons — dghindia.gov.in
- Petroleum and Natural Gas Regulatory Board — pngrb.gov.in
- Official Gazette of India notifications (for specific ESZ, CRZ and area-closure orders)